Briefing: Stack-Size Adjustments Through the Tournament Phases

Summary of two PokerCoaching videos (Matt Affleck's webinar on adjusting ranges to stack depth, and Jonathan Little's video on bubble strategy), with a comparison to the charts and solves in the Postflop Framework Drills. November 2026.

Summary

The webinar's thesis: as effective stacks get shorter, you play about the same number of hands but different ones. You swap small pairs, small suited connectors and wheel aces for offsuit Broadways and bigger suited aces, and you stack off with top pair far more readily. The presenter calls not making this shift one of the biggest and easiest-to-fix mistakes weaker tournament players make.

The five ideas that carry the rest:

- **Deep (150bb+), play for straights, flushes and sets.** Suitedness and connectedness matter most, and one pair is rarely good enough to play a 300bb pot.
- **At 50bb, play for strong top pairs.** Offsuit Broadways (KJo, KTo, ATo, A9o) gain value; 22–44, 54s/65s and A2s–A4s lose it.
- **Your open percentage barely changes.** A middle-position range goes from about 24% at 150bb to about 23% at 50bb; only the hand types change.
- **SPR drives everything.** Below an SPR of about 5, good top pairs can stack off and normal bet sizes get the money in by the river. Above 5, they can't, and you need a stronger hand.
- **Use effective stacks, not your own stack.** With 100bb against a table of 50bb stacks you are playing a 50bb game; with 40bb against 20bb stacks you are playing 20bb.

Scope: the main webinar is about stack depth, not tournament stages, and barely covers the bubble. A second PokerCoaching video, Jonathan Little on bubble strategy, fills that gap: ICM, risk premium, how each stack size should play, and 22 hand examples. It has its own section below. Neither video gives push/fold ranges.

Stack-depth bands

There is an inverse relationship: as stacks shrink, big offsuit cards gain value; as stacks grow, suited connectors and small pairs gain value. The webinar uses four bands.

EFFECTIVE STACK	TYPICAL POINT IN AN MTT	WHAT HANDS ARE FOR	GAINS VALUE	LOSES VALUE
150–200bb	First levels	Making better than one pair: straights, flushes, sets	Suited connectors and one-gappers, small pairs (set value), wheel aces (A2s–A5s)	Offsuit Broadways and offsuit aces: only AKo, AQo, KQo, AJo open from middle position, and AJo can be folded
~100bb	Early to middle	Middle ground	Big offsuit aces (AJo, AQo) start to matter; good top pairs can play for stacks in 3-bet pots	Suited connectors and small pairs keep some value
~50bb	Middle stages	Making strong top pairs	KJo, KTo, QJo, ATo, A9o; bigger suited aces (A9s–A6s)	22–44, 54s, 65s, 76s, 86s, T8s, J8s, A2s–A4s
≤15bb	Late, short	Shoving and re-jamming	Blockers (an ace in your hand)	Playability

Why hands like KJo improve at 50bb: one pair is never more likely to improve than another (AK and 32 make two pair equally often), but KQ on K-8-4 becomes a hand you can comfortably get all in with at 50bb, while at 150bb you need much more than top pair to stack off.

The middle-position example on the slides: going from 150bb to 50bb removes 70 combos (5.3% of hands: small pairs, small suited connectors, wheel aces) and adds 60 combos of offsuit Broadways, because offsuit hands have 12 combos to a suited hand's 4. The range drops by less than 1%: about 24% at 150bb to about 23% at 50bb.

A 3-bet pot at 100bb plays like a single-raised pot at 50bb. Open to 3bb, 3-bet to 10bb and call: the pot is about 20bb with about 90bb behind, an SPR of about 4.5.

3-betting and bet sizes by stack depth

The 3-bet bluffs change completely between 150bb and 50bb, and the value range gets wider as stacks shrink. The webinar's examples are a button 3-bet against a middle-position open.

	150BB	50BB
Value	JJ+, AK, AQs (about 44 combos)	Wider: adds TT, AQo, AQs, AJs, KQs
Bluffs	Small suited connectors and one-gappers (65s, 76s, 87s, 97s, 86s, 75s, T9s) and wheel aces (A5s, A4s), about 36 combos	Mid suited aces (A9s–A6s, plus A5s) and offsuit Broadways (AJo, KJo, ATo, KTo); also K9s, Q9s, J9s, T9s
Why these bluffs	Board coverage: they make straights, two pairs and flushes on low boards where a JJ+/AK range misses	Blockers to the 4-bet jam range (TT+, AK, AQ, AJ), and they flop top pairs that are easy to play
3-bet size in position	About 3.5× the open	About 2.7–3×
3-bet size out of position	4–4.5×	3.5–4×

Why 3-bet KTo but flat KQo at 50bb. A 3-bet bluff works by folding out better hands. KTo folds out KJ and often KQ (hands with about 70% equity against it), and ATo folds out AJ. KQo folds out almost nothing better, since AK and AQ never fold, and it folds out the KJ and KT you dominate. So flat KQo and keep those dominated hands in.

Why AQ and AJ become value 3-bets at 50bb. Most players jam AK over a 50bb 3-bet, so when they just call, AK is unlikely. AQ then plays almost face up as the best ace on A-high boards. At 150bb they may flat AK, so AQ has to be more careful.

Why A5s over A2s. A5s has more equity when called and blocks 56s on wheel boards; A2s and A3s add too many bluffs with less equity.

Facing a 4-bet jam at 50bb against typical small-stakes players, 3-bet the wider range but fold AQo, AQs, AJs and KQs to the jam: these players 4-bet only their best hands. Against aggressive players who 4-bet jam A5s or 55, call more of them, or 3-bet and call with them.

Kings deep. At 150–200bb it's common to flat 3-bets with KK, since aces are close to the only hand that wants to stack off. Stop stacking off kings against opponents who never 4-bet or 5-bet bluff. That's an opponent read, not a stack-size rule.

Bet sizing postflop follows the same logic. Deep, getting stacks in by the river takes pot-sized bets on every street (or more). At a low SPR, about ⅓ pot on the flop, ½ pot on the turn and a ⅔-pot river jam already gets it all in.

Opening sizes (presenter's own deep-stack approach). Min-raise or raise small under the gun, where you'll be out of position in a deep pot, and raise bigger (about 3×, even 4× early in a tournament) from the cutoff and button, where you'll be in position.

Facing big opens (to 10bb at 100–250bb, common in small live games). Mostly flat, even with QQ or JJ: the open already isolates. Call tighter, folding 66–44 and small suited connectors, and 3-bet only against players who will stack off light.

Opponent adjustments. These ranges are a baseline. Against players who never fold to 3-bets (common in $1 online tournaments), drop the bluffs and 3-bet a wider value range. Against tight openers, 3-bet less; against loose ones, 3-bet more. If there is a cold caller between you and the opener, tighten your 3-bets.

Effective stacks, short stacks and multiway spots

Always size your strategy to the effective stack, the smaller of the stacks involved, not your own. This was the most-asked question in the Q&A.

- **Big stack at a short table.** With 100bb against 45–50bb stacks, choose hands as if you have 50bb. With 40bb against 20bb stacks, play like 20bb and tighten up.
- **Don't bully just because you cover everyone.** Keep fundamentals and protect your chips. Open wider to pressure stacks only in ICM spots with big pay jumps, or against players who are folding too much.
- **Short stacks behind you (20–25bb) that keep jamming over opens.** Open tighter. Prefer hands that block their re-jam range: KJo over a hand like 76s, and an offsuit ace such as A4o gains value because the ace blocks their suited aces and big aces. With short stacks behind, blockers matter more than playability.
- **When to start push/fold.** The presenter starts open-jamming some hands at about 15bb, still min-raises a lot at 15bb, and does essentially no jamming above 15bb because he thinks his postflop edge is worth keeping.
- **Calling a 20bb shove.** With 40bb or 100bb, call almost the same range; only slightly tighter with the deeper stack because more is at risk.
- **Facing a 10bb under-the-gun jam with 66 in middle position (at 50bb).** Fold: 66 is ahead of the jamming range, but five players are left to act. From the small or big blind, closing the action, call.

Small pairs at 50bb. Don't call 3-bets to set-mine; the implied odds aren't there. Fold small pairs early, even up to about 66, when facing an early open with several players left to act who could squeeze. Call them when you close the action in the big blind. Deep, 22–44 can call 3-bets to set-mine, but watch out for set over set at 200bb.

Limpers deep. At 150bb with two early limpers, over-limp 44 rather than isolate: it doesn't block their calling range and hates most flops, so take a cheap flop.

Multiway pots have a lower SPR, so treat them as shallower: strong top pairs gain value, and it's easier to get the money in.

Cash games follow the same principles at the same depths. The webinar's ranges assume antes, so adjust for cash games without antes. The single big-blind ante changes strategy less than people think; it mainly speeds the game up.

Bubble strategy, ICM and risk premium

On the bubble, chips you lose are worth more than chips you win, so you need extra equity, the "risk premium", to call or make an all-in. This section comes from a second PokerCoaching video, Jonathan Little's "Mastering the fundamentals of bubble strategy". The bubble here means you're one or a few eliminations from the money, close enough that you could reasonably fold your way in.

Avoid going broke, but don't lock down. Collecting free equity as others bust is real money. But don't blind out by folding everything: many middle and short stacks tighten too early (say with 150 left and 100 paid), drift from 35bb to 20bb, min-cash, and wreck their chance of a deep run. A min-cash is about 1.5 buy-ins, not a big success.

Know the payout structure. Care about a pay jump only when it's meaningful: in the money with $150 locked, a jump to $156 doesn't matter, but a jump to $250 does. Top-heavy payouts (first used to get about 33% of the prize pool; now nearer 15%) reward gambling to win. Flatter modern payouts reward hanging on and moving up. Small local events are often steep.

Why it costs to gamble (ICM example). Four players each hold 25% of the chips; payouts are $1,000 / $700 / $400 / $200, so each stack is worth $575 on average.

OUTCOME OF A 50/50 ALL-IN BETWEEN TWO OF THEM	YOUR ICM EQUITY
Before the hand	$575
You win (double up)	$800
You lose (out in 4th)	$200
Average of win and lose	$500

Both players put in $575 of equity ($1,150 total) and get back $1,000 on average. The missing $150 goes to the two players who folded.

Every stack in the tournament matters, which is why there are no generic bubble charts. With 5bb when the average is 25bb, you can fold into the money if 300 are left and 299 get paid, or if several players have 1bb. If nine are left, everyone else has 20bb+ and you have 5bb, nobody else is likely to bust first: you'll have to double up or bubble.

Risk premium

When facing (or making) a bet for all or most of your chips, required equity = the pot-odds equity + a risk premium. If you lose you're out or crippled; if you win you don't double your equity. The premium depends on your stack and your opponent's, and applies when you bluff as well as when you call. The video's rough guide, for facing an all-in or near all-in at a final table or on the bubble:

YOU VS THE BETTOR	EXTRA EQUITY NEEDED
Short stack vs big stack (you're out if you lose)	About 9–15%
Short vs medium, short vs short	A little less than short vs big
Big stack vs big stack (both comfortably cashing)	About 18–35%
Big stack vs short stack	Very little: losing barely dents you

It can be much higher: with a 1bb stack in the tournament on the bubble, a short stack might need around 70% equity to call. Example: two 50bb stacks when the average is 20bb; QQ facing an all-in from AK is about 50%, but it needs about 70% after the risk premium, which is almost impossible preflop. So fold.

Worked example. Folded to a 40bb big stack in the small blind; you have 10bb in the big blind, with no tiny stacks around. The big stack should shove any two cards, because your risk premium is so large. You call 9bb to win 21bb, so 9 ÷ 21 = 42.8% without ICM. Add about 12% for the bubble and a margin for profit: you need about 56%. Against a 100% shoving range that means about 44+, A6s+, A8o+, K6s+, K8o+, Q8s+ and JTs. Call tighter still (about 99+, KJs+, ATo+) with shorter stacks elsewhere or when you're likely to cash anyway. If you're the obvious short stack and the next to bust, you can call a bit wider.

Opponents differ. Some players ignore ICM and play to win; others play very tight to cash. If an opponent defends loosely, tighten up (you don't want action); if they defend too tightly, loosen up. The presenter once ran over a final-table player who needed 4th place to pay off a house, then called him lighter (A10) the moment that player jammed once 4th was locked.

By stack role on the bubble

YOUR STACK	HOW TO PLAY
Biggest stack	Pressure everyone. Min-raise a lot (with medium to deep stacks), 3-bet medium stacks who open without accounting for ICM, call more in position, defend the big blind wide, and lead flops that suit your range. Still fold when clearly behind (for example A-K-Q against a 3-bettor) or when nobody is folding.
Medium stack	Pressure other medium stacks and the short stacks who are likely to cash. Avoid the big stacks, and tighten up a lot with a big stack on your direct left. If the big stack won't fight, play like the big stack.
Short stack	Pressure other short stacks; otherwise try to sneak into the money.

Aces as bubble bluffs. Ax offsuit and suited hands become good 3-bet and shove bluffs because the ace blocks the hands that can call or jam over you (AA, AK, AQ). When you bluff with payout implications, try to hold an ace.

Hand examples from the video (bubble)

HAND	STACKS AND ACTION	PLAY	WHY
A6o	You 100bb in position; 75bb cutoff raises	3-bet	Big stack applying pressure, especially with a 2–5bb stack in the tournament
T7s	You open the button; big blind 3-bets	Call	In position against a player with a big risk premium; bluff boards that suit you. Fold if the flop is A-K-Q and they bet
97s	Big stack, early position	Usually raise; fold if everyone is calling	Pressure only works if people fold
JJ	75bb; low-jack raises; short stacks in the tournament	Call, don't 3-bet	Avoid playing for 75bb on the bubble
K8s	75bb with 75bb and 100bb stacks to your left	Fold (maybe even KTs)	Big stacks behind will play back at you
A9o	75bb in the small blind facing a raise	Fold	Out of position on the bubble
96s	50bb; short stacks to your left and a 50bb big blind	Raise, if they're cautious and straightforward	Exploit players who won't fight
A5o	50bb in the small blind; raise and three calls	Squeeze small (to 1,500)	The ace blocks continuing hands; easy fold to a shove, big pot when they fold
AQs	40bb facing a raise	Call (a jam is profitable but risky)	"Chill out, don't go broke", especially with short stacks around
A5o	35bb facing a 40bb raise	Fold	Especially with shorter stacks in the tournament
AQs	35bb; raise, call, call	Jam or call	Call if there are 2bb stacks at other tables
A8o	30bb; 18bb hijack raises; others 20bb, one 10bb	Fold (3-bet bluff only against loose openers who fold)	Miserable when called
Q9s	30bb; hijack raises, cutoff calls	Squeeze all in	Risking about 2,000 chips; still about 10bb if it fails
ATs	30bb; raise and three calls	Jam (unless an obvious short stack)	Extra dead money in the pot
72s	25bb, first in	Min-raise; fold to a jam	Don't shove trash
AJo	Facing an 8bb jam from UTG+1	Often fold	Not automatic against a tight jammer; losing costs your big-stack edge
A2o	13bb in the small blind; button raises	Jam if the button opens too wide	Exploit wide openers who fold
Any jam	15bb on the button, the only shallow stack	Shove rather than min-raise	Don't leave yourself a marginal call-off
K2o	20bb; everyone else 10bb	Min-raise (also with your best hands); fold garbage to a shove	Don't jam hands that are dominated when called
97s	20bb	Shove	A min-raise commits you to a marginal call against a jam
K7o	11bb; small blind jams	Fold	Usually a call without ICM, but the payout implications cost too much
Q7o	6bb on the button	Fold	Usually an open-shove, but the big blind calls too often; wait for someone to bust

Postflop on the bubble

- **Big stack:** c-bet and lead far more often on boards that suit your range, usually with small bets: each bet nudges a medium stack closer to all in, and by the river their whole stack is at risk.

- **Triple barrel more** when the board runs out badly for them, for example a river that completes a straight they can't hold. Bluff catchers can't call profitably once the risk premium is included.
- **Short stack:** check-raise less, especially as a bluff; make bigger river folds even against bluffers; get out of pots early rather than reaching big river decisions.
- **Go broke only with a clear edge** (for example KK against a loose player who has lots of Ax), or when you're clearly the next to bust.

Stack-to-pot ratio (SPR)

SPR is the effective stack behind divided by the pot on the flop, and it decides how strong a hand must be to stack off. The rule of thumb: below about 5, good top pairs are strong enough to get all in; above 5, be cautious with one pair.

> SPR = effective stack behind ÷ pot on the flop

The webinar's two baseline examples (with a 1bb ante):

- 150bb, early-position 3× open, button calls: 8.5bb pot, 147bb behind, SPR about 17.
- 50bb, 2.5× open, button calls: 7.5bb pot, 47.5bb behind, SPR about 6.3.

Worked example: KQo opens in middle position, the button calls, flop Q-8-4 rainbow. You bet 5bb on the flop and 12.5bb on the 7♦ turn, and both get called. The river is the 9❤.

POINT IN THE HAND	40BB DEEP: POT / BEHIND / SPR	100BB DEEP: POT / BEHIND / SPR
Flop	7.5 / 37.5 / 5	7.5 / 97.5 / 13
Turn (after 5bb flop bet called)	17.5 / 32 / ~2	17.5 / 92.5 / ~5
River (after 12.5bb turn bet called)	42 / 20 / ~0.5	42 / 86 / ~2
Result	Jam the river for half pot; KQ is close to the top of a range that would have raised AQ, sets and two pairs earlier	Can't get stacks in without overbetting; the caller's range is stronger because AQ, sets, two pairs and straights (JTs) could all just call

Why the same hand is stronger shallow: at low SPR, opponents get their best hands in early (AQ raises or jams, sets and two pairs raise before a scary card), so the hands that just call down are weaker. Deep, they flat more strong hands and float more draws, so the calling range is stronger by the river.

Floating and drawing. Below an SPR of 5, calling a flop bet with a backdoor draw (say A♦2♦) is poor: if you miss, there's no room left to bluff the river. Above 5, there's enough behind to float, pick up draws and represent hands like JT, 56 or 98 on later streets.

Ranges are easier to read shallow. Hands like Q9o or JTo rarely call preflop at 50bb but may at 100bb, so deeper ranges hold more random two pairs and floats.

Cheat sheet

SITUATION	RULE OF THUMB
Which stack to use	Effective stack (the smaller one), never your own
150–200bb	Suited and connected hands, small pairs, wheel aces; very few offsuit hands; one pair rarely stacks off
50bb	Offsuit Broadways and bigger suited aces in; 22–44, small suited connectors and A2s–A4s out; good top pair can stack off
Open % from middle position	About the same at 150bb and 50bb (24% vs 23%); about 25% is the presenter's default
SPR	Below ~5: top pair can get it in. Above ~5: need more than one pair
3-bet bluffs, 150bb	Suited connectors, one-gappers, A5s/A4s
3-bet bluffs, 50bb	A9s–A6s, AJo/ATo/KJo/KTo, K9s/Q9s/J9s (block the 4-bet jam range)
3-bet value at 50bb	Wider: TT, AQ, AJs, KQs; fold AQ, AJs, KQs to a 4-bet jam from typical players
3-bet size	50bb: ~2.7–3× in position, 3.5–4× out of position. 150bb: ~3.5× in position, 4–4.5× out of position
Squeeze size, 150bb	UTG opens to 3bb, 3 callers (12bb in the pot): squeeze QQ to about 15–18bb
Getting it in at low SPR	⅓ pot flop, ½ pot turn, ⅔-pot river jam
Getting it in deep	Pot-sized bets every street, or overbets
Open sizes, deep	Small or min-raise early position; ~3× (up to 4×) from cutoff and button
Push/fold	Some open-jams from about 15bb; no jamming above 15bb
Calling a 20bb jam	Nearly the same range with 40bb or 100bb
Short stacks behind	Open tighter; prefer hands that block their re-jam range (KJo, offsuit aces)
Bubble: required equity	Pot odds + risk premium: short vs big +9–15%; big vs big +18–35%; big vs short very little
Bubble: 10bb big blind vs a 40bb small-blind jam	Need about 56% (44+, A6s+, A8o+, K6s+, K8o+, Q8s+, JTs); tighter with shorter stacks elsewhere
Bubble: big stack	Min-raise a lot, 3-bet and defend wide, small c-bets and leads; still fold when clearly behind
Bubble: medium stack	Pressure medium and short stacks; avoid big stacks, especially one on your left
Bubble: bluffs	Hold an ace: it blocks the hands that call or jam
Bubble: short stack	Shove rather than min-raise when you're the only short stack; fold marginal call-offs (K7o vs an 11bb jam)

How it compares with your charts and drills

Your PokerCoaching charts make the same core shift as the webinar, but more gradually and with a few differences. Figures below are from your charts (80bb is the deepest they go).

WEBINAR POINT	YOUR CHARTS	AGREES?
Open % stays about the same as stacks shrink	LJ opens 22.1% at 80bb, 22.9% at 50bb, 23.9% at 30bb, 21.9% at 20bb; HJ about 28% at 80 and 50bb	Yes
Small pairs drop out at 50bb	LJ: 22 never opened; 33 opened at 80bb, folded at 50bb; 44 half the time at 30bb, folded at 20bb	Yes, one depth band later for 44
Offsuit Broadways come in at 50bb	LJ A9o 25% at 80bb, 70% at 50bb, 100% at 30bb; KTo 40%, 60%, 100%	Yes
Small suited connectors drop out at 50bb	LJ still opens 65s, 76s, T8s, J8s at 50bb; they leave at 30bb (65s) and 20bb (76s); 54s is already mostly gone at 50bb	Partly: your charts drop them later
Wheel aces (A2s–A4s) drop out at 50bb	LJ and HJ still open A2s–A5s 100% at 50bb, 30bb and 20bb	No: your charts keep them as opens
3-bet bluffs move from wheel aces to offsuit Broadways	BTN vs LJ 3-bets A2s 95% at 80bb but 0% at 50bb; ATo 80% then 85%; AQo 35% then 60%; KTo 0% then 20%	Mostly; your 50bb chart still 3-bets A5s 85%
Small pairs lose value at 50bb	BTN still flats 22–66 against an LJ open at 50bb	Not for in-position flats; the webinar's point is about calling 3-bets and opening
Push/fold from about 15bb; min-raise a lot	Your 12bb charts open-shove 8% (UTG) to 27% (BTN) and still min-raise 8–11% of hands	Yes
Low SPR: top pair stacks off	Solver, BB 3-bet vs BTN at 50bb (SPR ~2.2): BTN goes all-in 25–45% of the time facing a ¾-pot bet on many boards	Yes
Shallower: smaller bets do the job	Solver, BB vs SB: SB bets ⅓ pot on K-7-2 57% at 50bb and 97% at 20bb	Yes

What to practise.

- **Range viewer:** open LJ or HJ and switch between 80, 50, 30 and 20bb to watch the small pairs and suited connectors leave and the offsuit Broadways arrive. Do the same for BTN vs LJ to see the 3-bet bluffs change.
- **Preflop trainer:** drill one depth at a time (50bb, then 30bb), with spot types limited to opens and facing a 3-bet.
- **12bb push/fold:** for the short-stack end the webinar skips.
- **Solver flop drill:** compare BTN vs BB at 50, 30 and 20bb, and the 3-bet pots, to see SPR change c-bet sizing and stack-off thresholds.

On the bubble, your charts and drills need adjusting. Your PokerCoaching charts, the 12bb push/fold page and the solver spots all assume chip EV, meaning no payout jumps. So on the bubble, call jams tighter than the charts by the risk premium. K7o facing an 11bb small-blind jam, normally a call, becomes a fold. Big stacks can open and jam wider than the charts against opponents who must play tight. The drills don't model ICM, so use the bubble section above as the adjustment layer on top of them.